in sixteen rattling hours. Indian railway journeys have their joys; but speed, comfort, and graciousness of service are not among them.

Leaving such refinements aside, the really telling difference between India and China in the transportation sector is in aviation and shipping. Here the disparities are enormous. In 2019, the Indian civil aviation fleet was a mere 669 aircraft. The corresponding number in China was 3772 aircraft, roughly five and a half times India's.[7] India's total air passenger traffic in 2018–19 was 316.51 million while China's was 1.35 billion. In 2019, India had 137 airports while China had 237 airports.[8] With respect to shipping, the disparities are gargantuan. One way of seeing this is to look at the total number of containers that ports handle. In 2018, Indian ports handled roughly 16.4 million containers. China by contrast handled 225.8 million, approximately fourteen times India's numbers. To get a sense of the scale of China's port operations, it handles two and a half times the volume of India, Japan, and the US combined.[9]

Beyond transportation, energy supplies are crucial for economic power. Here the imbalance between the two countries is huge. Aggregating across non-renewable and renewable sources, in 2018, India's electricity supply was 1,593,709 GWh and China's was 7,519,344 GWh.[10] In other words, China generates about five times the amount of electricity that India generates. Note that the Chinese economy is also roughly five times India's. While the mix of hydrocarbons and renewables in India and China is the same – roughly 85 per cent hydrocarbons – China's massive energy use is far more environmentally damaging if not unsustainable in a time of deepening climate change. To grow, India must increase its energy use, but to emulate China-like consumption would be catastrophic for climate change unless other countries reduced their consumption substantially. It is therefore unclear if India can ever match China's rates of energy consumption and explosive economic growth: at the present stage of technology, it is simply not possible to substitute renewables for non-renewables at levels that would put India on a high-growth path.